VIRTUOSO GUIDE TO
PERSONAL GROWTH

Satiate your constant drive to learn, explore, and expand in new directions

16Personalities

Table of Contents

Introduction 3
Motivation and Development 5
Self-Esteem 6
Balanced Self-Esteem 6
Unbalanced Self-Esteem. 6
Rebalancing Self-Esteem. 7
Self-Respect. 7
Balanced Self-Respect 8
Unbalanced Self-Respect 8
Rebalancing Self-Respect 9
Self-Confidence. 9
Balanced Self-Confidence 9
Unbalanced Self-Confidence 10
Rebalancing Self-Confidence 10
Pursuing Personal Growth 11
What Causes Most Problems for Virtuosos? . . 11
Where Virtuosos Shine 13
The Growing Virtuoso 15
Final Words. 16
So... What's Next? 17

Introduction

Why Personal Growth Matters to Virtuosos

Personal growth isn't the "one size fits all" affair that some self-help books would have you believe. It's about expanding beyond comfort and habit to explore new ways of existing. From the outside, Virtuosos can seem like a bundle of contradictions. Although they're typically rational, measured, and logical, sometimes they explode into spontaneity and unchecked enthusiasm – occasionally to the surprise of even those who know them well. The truth is, Virtuosos can be heady and changeable, but they hide these traits from the outside world, often very successfully. As a result, they may come across as enigmatic or unpredictable.

In general, Virtuosos are optimistic, generous, and confident in their abilities – if they aren't pushed into a corner, burdened with rules and guidelines, or asked to commit to something that they aren't yet ready for. Virtuosos chafe at boundaries, a quality that, when unbalanced, can be taken to the extreme. This might manifest as telling inappropriate jokes, indulging in risky behavior, or reacting to delicate situations in ways that are blunt, insensitive, or needlessly stubborn.

When Virtuosos recognize the need for personal growth, they can start by establishing a baseline for their function in the world, evaluating the efficiency of their behavior, and deciding whether it's fulfilling. With an objective look inward, these types may find ideas for improvement and then try new actions and attitudes to help accomplish them.

For Virtuosos to grow, they must first develop self-awareness, assessing themselves and their behaviors. Are those behaviors pleasant in the moment but harmful in the long term? Virtuosos should then ask themselves what they want from life, both now and in the future. This thinking need not box these types into rigid plans – considering the future can open new, more fulfilling possibilities. Growth's final step involves replacing unhealthy behaviors with new ones that bring Virtuosos closer to what they want in life.

Let's face it. Virtuosos will never fall in love with restrictions or constraints, but they can regulate their impulses by acting in accordance with their core values: fairness and equality. After all, true fairness involves taking others' views, feelings, and well-being into account – even when these considerations seem irrational or inefficient.

It's worth noting that personal growth isn't always the product of deliberate effort. Sometimes it emerges gently from the subtle shifts caused by age and maturity. From time to time, life prompts growth through hard times and crises. Virtuosos possess a wonderful enthusiasm for critical experimentation, and when they use this ability to inspire and manage their growth, life's inevitable changes are likely to be positive rather than random. As the saying goes, "You're either getting better, or you're getting worse. There's no staying the same."

In these pages, we'll explore the three motivational aspects that drive personal growth for Virtuosos: self-esteem, self-respect, and self-confidence. When Virtuosos enjoy balance across these three aspects, they are able to fully lean into and develop their inherent strengths.

Conscious personal growth is not about feeling *obligated* to change. Our goal is not to lay out a strict plan or guidelines, but rather to spur an inner drive for balance with ideas, encouragement, and gentle guidance for the possible problems that Virtuosos may encounter along life's way.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Motivation and Development

Virtuosos can work toward a more fulfilling life by focusing on three related, but distinct, motivational aspects of personal growth that relate to the way they look at themselves.

Motivation

- **Self-esteem** speaks to how much Virtuosos like themselves. Accepting both their flaws and strengths creates a base of internal appreciation that enables change motivated by desire instead of shame.
- **Self-respect** speaks to their sense of worth. People with this personality type value delivering useful results, and when they live their beliefs and values, a balanced sense of pride in who they are follows.
- **Self-confidence** is the energy source that moves Virtuosos forward in life. When using their skills to solve problems confirms their belief in their abilities, it drives them to make steady progress.

If these three core aspects are properly balanced, they can promote a successful and fulfilling life. If these elements become unbalanced, however, they become a source of overwhelming difficulty. For example, when Virtuosos feel a lack of self-confidence, they might compensate by falling back on doing something that's too easy for their skill level, giving them a temporary (and diminishing) boost and stalling the advancement that they value.

Moving Forward

When inspired to pursue personal growth, Virtuosos seek new ways to be happier and more successful – including an independent and personal definition of success. In the following sections, we'll first examine Virtuosos' characteristics in their ideal, balanced, and developed form. Next, we'll describe the tendencies that emerge if these aspects become unbalanced. These represent departures from healthy, productive motivational strategies and explain adverse effects that Virtuosos experience when they disconnect from their true selves. Finally, we'll discuss what can be done to improve balance in each of the motivational aspects. Suggestions are provided throughout to aid the process of personal growth and development.

Self-Esteem

It's common for rational people to struggle with reconciling their emotions with their intellect, which Virtuosos often apply to their mastery of skills. People with the Virtuoso personality type who maintain harmony between the two create strong foundations in their lives that bring stability and satisfaction. Conflict between their drive and the rest of their lives can inhibit happiness and dry up inspiration, while a sense that they've balanced the two can allow good things to happen. Virtuosos must decide how to satisfy their self-esteem fueled drive to be competent while appreciating the other parts of their lives.

Balanced Self-Esteem

Exploring Their Ability

A sense of competence and mastery drives Virtuosos' self-esteem engine. These types never want to settle for "good enough." Combining their natural curiosity, their extraordinary perception, and their creative edge, life beckons them to discover how far a project can go. This naturally leads to mastery of a skill or a situation. Without this sense of mastery, Virtuosos are likely to feel a lack of completeness.

Even if they do something well, unless they feel like they've done it expertly, Virtuosos may feel like they haven't met their potential. They strive to take any skill or achievement, large or small, to the next level until they can perfect it no further. Virtuosos with a well-balanced sense of self-esteem admire the challenge of any problem, do the job, and do it well.

Unbalanced Self-Esteem

How Far Is Too Far?

Is there such a thing as too much mastery? Not exactly. But Virtuosos must decide if the intense focus it takes to develop expertise is worth certain sacrifices when all is said and done. In their wish to excel in any field they enter or any problem they seek to solve, Virtuosos may not consider the collateral damage that others may suffer because of their search for perfection.

Sometimes Virtuosos must choose between focusing on their goals and caring for the needs of others. When this happens, they too easily place others further down on their priority list. They don't do this because they dislike people. They often try to be kind and useful to others. However, they may perceive others as obstacles when they're working hard to master something. This is especially difficult if they feel that it's a loved one in the way. In extreme cases, Virtuosos might achieve the mastery that they crave but lose the dependability of those around them.

Rebalancing Self-Esteem

Master the Big Picture

Virtuosos must try to grasp the big picture to moderate an overblown need for mastery that can quickly evolve into an obsession. A view of the overall picture can show them that sacrificing dependability and relationships for personal accomplishment does more harm than good in the end. Sometimes the larger plan must trump all other impulses, even the best.

Many philosophers throughout time have said in different ways what the philosopher Voltaire penned, "The best is the enemy of the good." Virtuosos would do well to stop and consider this. Instead of obsessing over things they can master, every so often they must subordinate this desire to a goal that's "good enough" and preserves teamwork and relationship building instead. Perhaps, to balance their self-esteem needs better, they should "master" working with others.

Self-Respect

For Virtuosos, self-respect comes from their ability to think on their feet and solve problems on almost an improvisational level. Their self-respect doesn't involve deep deliberation. They prefer the action encompassed in assessing a situation and providing a hands-on solution. It doesn't matter which discipline they master – the dynamic is the same. They like to think of themselves as able to manipulate the different parts of their specialty to provide results.

Balanced Self-Respect

These types affirm their own worth when they see themselves as flexible and able to deal skillfully with unexpected things. "Steady as she goes" brings no sense of fulfillment to Virtuosos, because they assess themselves by how well they solve problems, and to solve a problem, you need a problem. While most types like a measure of stability, Virtuosos find little satisfaction in staying on metaphorical "solid ground." They feel better about themselves after they've navigated choppy waters and figured out how to keep the boat upright. There's no sense of accomplishment for them in sitting around being content. Their skills at handling sudden predicaments drive their self-respect.

Because of this, there's nothing like having Virtuosos around during a crisis – and Virtuosos never feel better about themselves than when they're effectively dealing with one. If there's an emergency, find a Virtuoso. They'll take care of the situation and gain a feeling of pride simultaneously. Having the skills and flexibility to take care of such matters helps them to respect themselves.

Unbalanced Self-Respect

The most significant problem that people with the Virtuoso personality type can face is that everybody else in the world *isn't* a Virtuoso. To feel more self-respect, some Virtuosos may resort to seeking difficulties to conquer or take risks just to prove their worth to themselves. While they continue to look for problems to solve and things to conquer, family, friends, and coworkers may not be so interested in constantly facing down difficulties that show off their skills.

Others may come to see Virtuosos as careless or even undependable. In a social or work setting, this can cause a lot of disharmony. To make these conflicts even worse, Virtuosos may not care that much about others' opinions when they find themselves "on a mission." Such disregard for friends, business associates, and loved ones can be damaging. When this motivational engine is out of balance, Virtuosos may value themselves as they solve problems, but they may also find that others aren't so enamored with them. Virtuosos can try to understand that boosting their self-respect at the expense of others may make their lives less than satisfying when all is said and done.

Rebalancing Self-Respect

"Reframing" is a psychological trick that people can play on themselves to shift their perspectives. This helps them create new attitudes or encourages new behavior to help them respond to things differently.

Virtuosos who ignore other people while overzealously trying to meet their personal agendas can instead try to reframe their social or business network. They can try to see it as another puzzle that they need to solve or another skill to attain. Can they master relationships as well as they master other things?

Virtuosos might look at each unhappy person in their social constellation as a challenge. If a spouse or friend is upset, then what can these types do to help them feel better? If the boss is unhappy with their too-narrow focus on a particular issue, what can be done to solve the "boss problem?" These are all worthy challenges for Virtuosos who choose to think about them that way.

Self-Confidence

While it might sound circular, Virtuosos gain confidence when they can act in confident ways. Their bold actions send themselves the message that they're on the right track and can move forward confidently. Trying new things drives Virtuosos' self-confidence, and the fact that an action is bold is often the only sign of success they need.

Balanced Self-Confidence

Many credit the German writer and statesman Goethe with saying, "Boldness has genius, power, and magic in it. Begin it now." This quotation is music to the ears of Virtuosos. A sense of boldness gives them the thrust they need to move forward in life. They have little regard for traditional standards or rules because they're too confining and limit Virtuosos' creative imagination.

The acts of boldly finding new places to be (metaphorically or literally) and new ways to do things pull Virtuosos confidently into the future. The "next new thing" energizes them. They love change where others dread it. Attraction to bold innovation and problem-solving is what gives them energy and confidence.

Unbalanced Self-Confidence

Cultures often admire boldness. Heroes are often those who are bold and act in bigger-than-life ways. The need to feel confident can become so strong that Virtuosos begin acting boldly simply for its own sake, and their desire to solve problems sometimes attracts them to chaos. Such daring action can disconnect Virtuosos from anything that's meaningful, such as business plans with conventional idea, security based on maintaining stability, and all the other things which make most people feel secure. This can be damaging, as those around them most likely prefer playing it safe.

This, in turn, can abruptly remove Virtuosos from their social or career networks if taken too far. Rules are often broken amid bold moves. While they move forward with great bluster, those around them may shake their heads at what they see as erratic and irresponsible behavior.

Rebalancing Self-Confidence

Mission statements describing the visions of organizations or individuals have become a staple for goal-setting and self-improvement. Virtuosos would do well to spend a little time expanding their comfort zones and creating their own mission statements. Planning in such a structured way doesn't come naturally to them. But everyone needs a North Star to guide their travels – and such a star can help Virtuosos moderate their actions enough to avoid being disruptive. They may want to review the mission statement of any organization to which they belong and consider these guidelines to be rules they can honor and uphold.

Virtuosos are independent and are likely to put their own spin on anything they do, but such a statement can help them stay in touch with what's relevant and important to others or to themselves. Such maps can help them remain on the road to relevant outcomes even when their need to express their boldness urges them to veer off it. Virtuosos can consider this a counterbalance to their Prospecting trait that can help them stay in touch with the bigger picture and the needs and goals of others.

Pursuing Personal Growth

Growth is about acquiring the knowledge and experience that enhances one's life skills – and the operative word here is "skills." From this perspective, Virtuosos are likely to dive deeply into personal growth. After all, it's just knowing how to leverage their strengths and learning to compensate for their weaknesses. This is surely something that would appeal to Virtuosos, and life is just one more thing for them to master.

What Causes Most Problems for Virtuosos?

Impulsive Thrill-Seekers

Virtuosos often enjoy giving in to their impulses and desires so much that the line between what's acceptable and what isn't can quickly become very blurry. Deeply utilitarian at heart, they're unlikely to worry too much about this, but it's essential for them to know the consequences of their actions and not be too selfish or hurt anyone else. Otherwise, people with this personality type can be in danger of drifting toward purely sensual or even antisocial activities. Virtuosos have the potential to become outstanding maestros in any field they choose – but to achieve this, they must learn how to rein in their spontaneity. While they never want to squelch it entirely, learning to moderate it can be helpful.

Virtuosos have a sensation-seeking personality and are fascinated by things they can experience with their five senses. Abstract, theoretical matters don't interest them as much – people with this personality type seek sensual rather than mental stimulation. They're also one of the most impulsive and hot-blooded types, cherishing variety and unpredictability. This is one of the reasons why they tend to fare well in the military, especially if they get a chance to operate some type of machinery. Sometimes, they may even come up with artificial challenges or issues just to liven up the environment – Virtuosos can't stand boredom and routine.

However, it's important to keep this trait in check. Otherwise, they may find themselves in a downward spiral of taking ever greater risks and seeking ever stronger sensations, all in the name of thrill and variety. This can be especially destructive in romantic relationships – their lovers can either get stressed out because of increasing instability,

or join their Virtuoso partners, encouraging their adrenaline-seeking behavior more than perhaps they should.

Overly Optimistic

Virtuosos also tend to be over-optimistic and even careless, both inside and outside their professional environments. They tend to have nerves of steel and are likely used to close brushes with danger, always saved by their highly developed observation skills and willingness to do everything and anything to achieve the desired goal. However, even Virtuosos sometimes run out of luck, and there needs to be a balance between their self-confidence and self-doubt. People with this personality type often find it difficult to resist an urge to do something, but it's important to learn to put everything in perspective.

It's their optimism and belief in their abilities that allow Virtuosos to notice and take advantage of various opportunities; however, such traits may also push them to make rash and misinformed decisions, especially if Virtuosos lack experience in those specific areas. Furthermore, other people may use this to diminish Virtuosos' contributions, instead focusing all the attention on mistakes they've made or matters they've left unattended. If possible, Virtuosos should try to join forces with others who are more meticulous and disciplined, as such partnerships allow their own strengths to flourish.

Developing Emotional Intelligence

Virtuosos may also want to focus on their emotional intelligence. People with this personality type are likely to be quite reserved, paying more attention to their tools as opposed to other people – and even when they socialize, they're unlikely to care much about connecting with others on an emotional level. Similarly, Virtuosos are likely to have significant difficulties expressing their own feelings, and their romantic partners may perceive them as cold and calculating.

Virtuosos are no-nonsense people, always keeping their feet on the ground. This trait is a great asset when it comes to artisanship and professional goals, but it's also important they learn to respond to others' emotions, especially outside the professional environment. If such skills are left underdeveloped, their partners are likely to feel

something is missing from their relationships. Virtuosos may be unable or unwilling to open up and let others get close to them, always focusing on what's fun and avoiding what's uncomfortable or painful.

Emotions do influence the decisions that Virtuosos make, at least to some extent, even though most people with this personality type try hard to make decisions and solve problems without involving their feelings. How humans process is also how humans feel, and vice versa – this applies to Virtuosos as well. However, these types more naturally deal with such emotions internally, without exposing them to the outside world. Therefore, they may radiate an aura of logic and detachment.

Where Virtuosos Shine

Excellent Improvisers

Virtuosos' most impressive trait of all is their ability to "think on their feet" – people with this personality type can easily make snap decisions and are seemingly always able to escape even the most challenging situations. This makes them excellent improvisers, especially when there's a need to act quickly and come up with an idea without prior planning. Virtuosos are fiercely utilitarian, willing to do what it takes to get the job done, even if it means breaking existing traditions – and they also tend to be stereotypical lone wolves, choosing to work alone whenever possible. This attitude may not win them many friends among the more cooperative and stability-oriented types (usually Diplomats and Sentinels) but it's likely to give them the reputation of highly effective artisans, whatever their crafts may be.

That being said, Virtuosos should pay attention to their tendency to focus on their primary goals and leave all other tasks aside, as this allows them to move quickly but poses a danger to their legacy once the main task is finished. Other people, especially those opposed to Virtuosos' "Let's get this done!" attitude, may often point fingers at all the little unfinished things or overlooked procedures, ignoring Virtuosos' main achievements. As already mentioned above, these types are at their best when they pair with others who can sort out the logistics behind the operation – Virtuosos tend to be brilliant craftsmen and improvisers, but mediocre administrators or logisticians.

Virtuosos are bold and able to both notice and act on opportunities that other types can't or don't want to. People with this personality type shouldn't be reluctant to embrace their spontaneity if the circumstances are right – they're very well equipped to deal with unexpected challenges and succeed with scarce resources. Virtuosos can excel in the most unfavorable environments, knowing exactly how far they can push limits, what tactics they can pursue, and which resources they can employ.

Utilizing Their Skills and Strengths

The term "Explorer" can mean many different things when talking about Virtuosos – many of them are explorers in the real sense of the word, but some also choose to use their excellent grasp of the real world in other areas, such as medicine or extreme sports. There's no other personality type as adept at noticing what is likely to excite the senses and then exploiting it – for instance, Virtuosos can easily become masterful musicians or sportsmen. This peculiar trait usually makes them very creative and productive individuals, especially once they get enough freedom to follow their own paths.

Known for their cleverness, ingenuity, and artisan skills, Virtuosos should do their best to find a niche that's right for them, and then follow their instincts instead of listening to critics and naysayers. To paraphrase playwright George Bernard Shaw, "The careful man adapts himself to the world; the reckless one persists in trying to adapt the world to himself. Therefore, all progress depends on the reckless man." It's important for these types to know their limitations, while not being afraid to capitalize on their strengths. No other personality type knows how to enjoy the present moment as much as they do, and no one should underestimate the importance of their skills.

Unpredictable and Exciting

Virtuosos' boldness and thirst for adrenaline are also likely to be very attractive to other people, including potential romantic partners. Just like many other things in their lives, Virtuosos' relationships are full of both excitement and unpredictability, as they're always able to find something interesting to do to keep the flames burning brightly.

However, Virtuosos often avoid commitment: knowing full well that life is unpredictable, they're likely to choose to live in the present instead of planning for the future. Many Virtuosos are perfectly happy with this approach – after all, "Seize the day!" is their motto – however, it's important to remember that many other people expect their love interests to fully commit to their relationships relatively early and may get hurt if their Virtuoso lovers don't seem that interested.

People with this personality type don't need to worry too much about attracting partners as it's likely their partners will find them instead. However, Virtuosos may need to work on recognizing (and, if necessary, managing) their partners' expectations if they want to have strong, lasting relationships. The same principles apply to non-romantic relationships as well – friends, coworkers, and others may also be surprised by their unwillingness to settle down and stop wandering.

The Growing Virtuoso

Virtuosos find that acting in ways that bring about effective and immediate results gives them meaning and purpose, and they always seek to develop on that level. They hone their very lives to be fine and effective tools. Such refinement of themselves, as artisans in all senses of the word, is Virtuosos' easy, preferred manner of growth.

The harder way that Virtuosos can grow involves stopping long enough to thoughtfully plan and create consistency in their lives. Taking the time to see how other people are doing in the midst of their flurry of activity can bring them more satisfaction. Most people need others to comfortably fit into their lives – and there's happiness for Virtuosos who figure out how to do this well.

There are classes everywhere called "life skills classes," verifying what everyone already knows. Life is a skill. It involves skill building. It's something to tinker with. It's something to polish. Developing a life and attaining personal growth fits Virtuosos' foundational skill set perfectly.

Final Words

Creatively Practical

As Aristotle said millennia ago, "The hardest victory is over self." Self-reliant and practical, but with a strong streak of creativity, Virtuosos have a distinct set of traits inherent in their personality that leaves them well-equipped to take on the challenges of personal growth and learning to handle day-to-day situations in healthy, well-balanced ways. Sure, it can be a challenge for them to work for things with a distant or unexciting payoff, but when they harness their passion and administer just enough self-discipline, they can move heaven and earth.

When it comes to moving forward, and putting the insights found within personality theory to work, we tend to encourage most types to make a plan that uses their strengths. But the truth is, Virtuosos aren't likely to heed such advice. People with this personality type rarely see a complex and theoretical plan as necessary to the action that they crave.

But Virtuosos do know how to prioritize without the need to spell anything out ahead of time. When they prioritize their personal growth as if it were yet another project, they will – without a doubt – find the balance that they need to live purposeful and satisfying lives.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you build a strong foundation for your self-development? Explore our Personal Growth Specialized Tests.
- Looking to enhance your academic or professional life? Check out the *Virtuoso Guide to Careers*.
- Ready to better understand and strengthen your relationships? Our *Virtuoso Guide to Relationships* may be just what you need.

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